pulling out a surprise, that too in the midst of high-stakes elections elsewhere—it chose B.Y. Vijayendra, first-time MLA and son of party veteran and former CM B.S. Yediyurappa, as state president. As a senior partyman says, "Nobody anticipated it." Indeed, while Vijayendra had been in the running, the names of several seniors, too, were in circulation as probables, including that of Union minister of state for agriculture Shobha Karandlaje. However, in choosing the 48-year-old Vijayendra as party chief, the party has signalled that it is looking to recoup its voter base ahead of the Lok Sabha election.

Karnataka is the only southern state that has consistently delivered a healthy tally of Lok Sabha seats for the BJP over the past two decades. For instance, in the 2019 polls, the party made a near-clean sweep, winning 25 out of the 28 Lok Sabha seats in the state. But the May assembly polls in which the Congress succeeded in stitching together a broad coalition of caste groups, including the politically dominant Lingayat community that has been a mainstay of the BJP, came as a wake-up call. Following Yediyurappa's retirement in February—when the Lingayat strongman turned 80—not only was the BJP unable to project a leader who could step into his shoes, but it also ended up alienating a few seniors from the community who switched sides to the Congress. The move to appoint Vijayendra as state president, therefore, was aimed at removing any "confusion in the Lingayat votes", says the senior party functionary quoted earlier. "This is a test of his leadership qualities," he adds.

Counter-balancing this was the appointment of senior Karnataka leader R. Ashoka as the LoP. A former deputy CM and minister for revenue between 2019 and 2023, Ashoka, 66, hails from the Vokkaliga community, the other dominant caste group in Karnataka. While

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ON THE HOUSE Leader of the Opposition, BJP's R. Ashoka at a protest against the Congress government

VIJAYENDRA'S APPOINTMENT AS STATE BJP CHIEF IS A SIGNAL TO THE LINGAYATS, AND THE CHOICE OF R. ASHOKA AS LoP IS AIMED AT THE VOKKALIGAS

the BJP was seen to be pursuing a 'hard ideological' line with party appointments in Karnataka in the recent past, "it looks like they are going back to the more acceptable caste combination," says Bengaluru-based political commentator and economist Prof. Narendar Pani. The non-Congress parties in Karnataka, he points out, have always relied on a Lingayat-Vokkaliga combination.

Vijayendra, who practised law briefly before going on to become a general secretary of the BJP Yuva Morcha, was till recently a party vice-president. In 2019, his stock as a campaigner rose after he oversaw two assembly byelection victories in KR Pet and Sira—a first for the party and important for their being located in the Old Mysuru region, where it has a weak footprint. Last month, soon after taking charge as state president, Vijayendra got down to meeting booth presidents in Bengaluru, Mysuru and Kolar while also visiting a dozen or so prominent 'mathas', or religious institutions, of various communities.

Both these appointments, however, have also caused some degree of heartburn among seniors in the Karnataka BJP who were overlooked. For instance, Vijayapura legislator Basanagouda Patil Yatnal, who was in the running for the post of LoP, complained that his party had neglected the northern Karnataka region by picking Vijayendra and Ashoka—who come from Shivamogga and Bengaluru, respectively—for the two posts. Besides, Vijayendra's older brother B.Y. Raghavendra is currently the Lok Sabha MP from Shivamogga—this family connection, and the BJP's willingness for a pre-poll alliance with the Janata Dal (Secular), a party it has often criticised for its *parivarvaad*, can blunt its attack on 'dynasty politics'.

Since its emphatic victory in the May election, Karnataka's ruling Congress has set for itself a target of 20 seats in the Lok Sabha election in 2024. Working towards that goal, over the past few months, the party has netted several local leaders from rivals BJP and Janata Dal (Secular) and says it is looking for potential candidates in several seats.

This is reason enough for the BJP's Karnataka unit to get its act together. For the new team in place, the party's recent victories in Madhya Pradesh, Chhattisgarh and Rajasthan could provide a much-needed morale-booster. ■